

CLASSIFIED

THE GOBEKLI TEPE INVESTIGATION

Sanliurfa Province, Turkey. 37.2231 N, 38.9225 E

CASE NO.:	HE-127-GT
FILE OPENED:	1994
STATUS:	UNRESOLVED - ACTIVE
DISTRIBUTION:	PURCHASER COPY - PERSONAL LICENSE

DO NOT CIRCULATE

CASE SUMMARY

The oldest temple on Earth was built by people who officially did not have architecture. Gobekli Tepe is seven thousand years older than Stonehenge, six thousand years older than the first Egyptian pyramid, and it was built, per the textbook, by hunter-gatherers who had no towns, no farms, no pottery and no metal.

Then, after roughly a thousand years of use, the builders did something no one has explained. They buried it. Not abandoned it. Buried it, deliberately, under thousands of tons of fill, so completely that it survived intact until 1994.

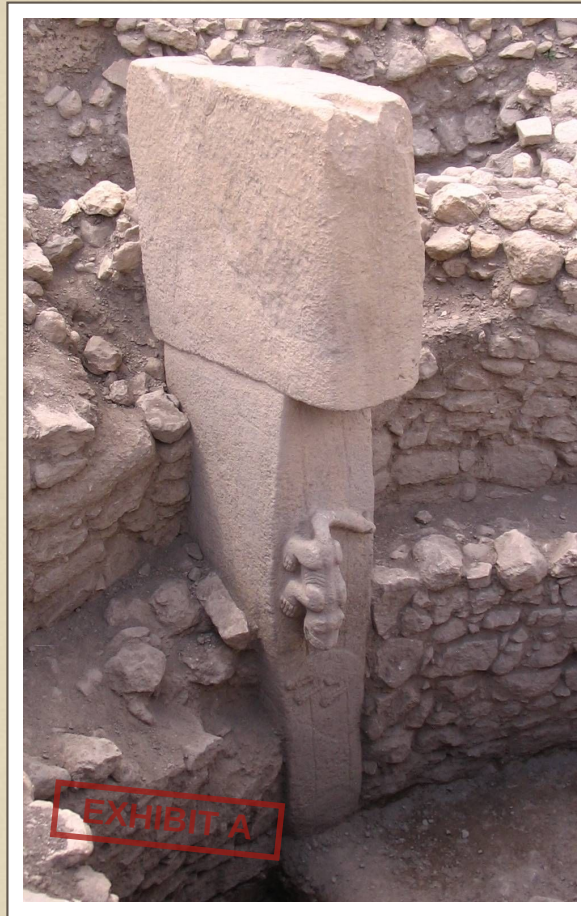
This file collects the excavation record, the radiocarbon dates, and the details the summary articles leave out. It also collects what the summary articles will never print: the teachers the ancient world itself named, the sky event carved into the pillars, the sister sites still coming out of the ground across the region, and the reasons excavation of the most important site on Earth has slowed to a crawl.

The question of record: who taught the first builders, and what was worth hiding for eleven thousand years.

TIMELINE OF RECORD

- | | |
|---------------------|--|
| c. 10,900 BC | The Younger Dryas begins. Something strikes the planet at the end of the Ice Age: temperatures collapse within a decade, the megafauna die, and a platinum-rich dust layer settles across three continents. Every flood tradition on Earth points its memory at this window. |
| c. 9600 BC | The Younger Dryas ends, abruptly, and the earliest enclosures at Gobekli Tepe rise within the same era. The dates come from carbonate layers and charcoal in the fill and are not disputed. Monumental architecture begins on this hill, immediately after the catastrophe, out of nothing. |
| c. 9400 BC | Karahan Tepe, twenty-three miles away, is active in the same period: pillars, rock-cut chambers, and a bed of carved stone phalluses watched by a stone head emerging from the wall. It is one of at least a dozen related sites now known as the Tas Tepeler. The complex was a civilization, not a temple. |

c. 8000 BC	Gobekli Tepe is deliberately backfilled and abandoned. The burial preserves it. No account of why exists.
1963	A joint Istanbul and Chicago survey walks the mound, notes broken limestone slabs, and files it as a medieval cemetery. The oldest temple on Earth is logged and dismissed in one afternoon.
1994	Klaus Schmidt of the German Archaeological Institute rereads the 1963 report, visits the hill, and recognizes the slabs as prehistoric within minutes of arrival. FILE OPENED.
1995	Excavation begins. T-shaped monoliths up to 5.5 meters and roughly 10 tons emerge, arranged in circles, carved in relief with foxes, snakes, scorpions, vultures and human hands.
2014	Schmidt dies suddenly at 61, swimming, one year after publishing his synthesis. The site's excavation tempo changes character after his death. His central claim, the temple came before the farm, is still the accepted reading of the site.
2017	Engravings on Pillar 43, the Vulture Stone, are read by two Edinburgh engineers as a date code marking the Younger Dryas impact event, c. 10,890 BC. The interpretation is contested. The carving is not.
2010s	Under a conservation program, olive and fruit orchards stand over unexcavated zones of the mound and permanent roofing is installed above the open trenches. Deep-root agriculture and construction footings now sit on top of the ninety percent of the site nobody has seen.
Present	Less than ten percent of the site has been excavated. Ground radar shows at least fifteen more enclosures still under the fill. At current pace, the hill outlives everyone reading this file.



Predator sculpture emerging from the fill, photographed May 2008 during the Schmidt excavation. The animal is carved in the round, claws braced, descending the pillar toward the viewer. It spent eleven and a half thousand years underground exactly like this, because the builders put it there on purpose.

Source: Excavation photograph, May 2008. Released to the public domain by the photographer.

THE OFFICIAL STORY

The consensus position, and it is worth being precise, because the consensus here is already extraordinary. Around 9600 BC, mobile bands of foragers gathered seasonally on this hill, quarried ten-ton limestone pillars with flint tools, moved them hundreds of meters without draft animals or the wheel, raised them into sockets, and carved them with a fixed symbolic repertoire that repeats across enclosures and across centuries.

The textbooks absorbed this by moving one line: religion now comes before agriculture. The temple built the town, not the town the temple. What the textbooks did not absorb is what that concedes. Organized engineering, division of labor, a shared symbol system and multi-generational planning

all existed before the domestication of a single plant. The skills arrive at the beginning of the record, already formed.

Hold the official story to its own arithmetic. It asks for architects with no prior buildings, engineers with no prior loads, sculptors with no prior sculpture, and a labor force of hundreds fed by no farms, coordinated by no writing, for centuries, at a dozen sites simultaneously across the region. The textbook calls this the dawn of civilization. A dawn is gradual. This is a light switch.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

The oldest enclosures are the best ones. This is the detail that breaks the gradual-development story, and it is in the excavation reports in plain language. Enclosure D, among the earliest layers, has the largest pillars, the finest relief carving and the most precise layout. The later structures are smaller, cruder and simpler. The skill curve at Gobekli Tepe runs backward. Whoever built it arrived knowing how, and the knowledge decayed from there.

The pillars themselves are not abstract posts. The T-shapes have arms, hands and belts carved in low relief. They are stylized beings, standing in circles, faces never shown. The excavators called the two central pillars of each enclosure a pair of [REDACTED] facing one another. Ten tons each, faceless, wearing belts, eleven and a half thousand years old. The site's own builders knew beings the carvings refuse to show a face for. So does the nine-foot Urfa Man statue found in the nearby town, the oldest life-size statue of a human on Earth, with obsidian eyes and no mouth. Whatever these figures represented, the first sculptors in history were careful about how much of them to depict.

The burial is the part with no parallel anywhere. Around 8000 BC the builders filled their own temple with rubble, bone and flint debris, carried in on purpose, enclosure by enclosure. This took organized labor comparable to building it. Cultures abandon sites constantly. They do not enter them. You bury something to end it, or to keep it, or to keep it from someone. The report language calls it intentional decommissioning and moves on. The file does not move on.

And the timing. The site rises within centuries of the Younger Dryas, the abrupt climate catastrophe that ended the Ice Age, the same window every flood tradition on Earth points back to, and the same window Plato's priests gave Solon for the destruction of Atlantis, nine thousand years

before his visit, which lands at roughly 9600 BC. The official position treats that as coincidence. The file notes that Plato's number and the radiocarbon dates from this hill agree to within a rounding error, and Plato had no radiocarbon.



The bird-human relief, limestone, catalog MNR.23450. A figure that is not quite a bird and not quite a man, cut by people who officially had no sculptural tradition to learn from. The repertoire it belongs to appears at the site fully formed, repeats for a thousand years, and is found nowhere earlier on Earth.

Source: Gobekli Tepe find, inv. MNR.23450. Photograph released CC0 via Wikimedia Commons.

UNSANCTIONED EXPLANATIONS

The official account explains the site by declaring it explained. This office records the theories that account for the backward skill curve, the burial, and the date, and notes that the ancient world itself endorsed the first of them in writing.

THEORY ONE. THE TEACHERS. Sumer, the first literate civilization, and the nearest one downstream of this region, recorded exactly how its knowledge arrived: beings called the Apkallu, seven sages sent after the flood, taught mankind architecture, agriculture and law. The Babylonian priest Berossus wrote that before the flood, a being called Oannes emerged from the water and gave men letters, sciences, temples and cities, and that since that time no further inventions have been made. Read that last clause again. The first historians of civilization stated, as fact, that the knowledge was delivered, complete, at the start. That is precisely the shape of the evidence at Gobekli Tepe: best work first, decay after. The textbook and the tablet disagree, and the tablet was there first.

THEORY TWO. THE SURVIVORS. The Younger Dryas catastrophe destroyed a civilization the record barely holds, and its survivors, arriving in the highlands where the water never reached, directed the hunter-gatherers they found there. This is the Hancock reading and it fits every anomaly in the file: the light-switch start, the imported competence, the memorial carving of the sky on the night everything died, and the location, the highlands above Mesopotamia, exactly where the flood traditions land their arks. Mount Ararat stands in sight of this region. The mountains of Ararat is where Genesis parks the boat. The first temple after the flood was built a short walk from where the survivors are said to have come ashore.

THEORY THREE. THE WATCHERS. The Book of Enoch, scripture to the ancient world and quoted in the New Testament, names the beings who descended in the days before the flood and taught forbidden knowledge to mankind: the Watchers, two hundred of them, who came down on a mountain in this same upland arc and took wives and taught the cutting of stones, among other arts the text lists as sins. The T-pillars stand in circles, humanoid, faceless, belted, arms folded, exactly the form a culture would give to beings it remembered but was forbidden, or afraid, to depict. The enclosures were then buried by the very people who built them. Enoch says the works of the Watchers were condemned to be sealed away until a distant generation. The builders of Gobekli Tepe sealed their site so thoroughly it reached a distant generation intact. This office merely places the two statements side by side.

THEORY FOUR. THE SKY RECORD. The Edinburgh analysis of Pillar 43 reads the animal figures as constellations and the carved date as the summer solstice of 10,950 BC, within margin of the Younger Dryas impact layer. A companion carving shows a headless man, the toll. On this reading the site is not just a temple, it is an observatory and an archive, built by people determined that the date of the catastrophe never be forgotten, staffed for

a thousand years, and then buried, the way you seal a vault when the custodians can no longer guarantee the guard.

THEORY FIVE. THE TIME CAPSULE. Combine the above and the burial explains itself. The builders were not decommissioning a ruin. They were transmitting. A message cut in stone, interred beyond the reach of weather, war and revision, addressed to whoever would come after the next turning of the cycle. The site survived eleven and a half thousand years and arrived at the one century capable of reading a star map carved in limestone. If it was a message, it was a successful one, and the fifteen unopened enclosures under the orchard are the rest of it.

ANOMALIES ON FILE

ITEM 1. No settlement debris matches the labor scale. The workforce required runs to hundreds; the domestic traces found are thin scatter. The builders came from somewhere that has not been found.

ITEM 2. The craftsmanship is best at the bottom. Skill entering the record fully formed and then degrading is the signature of inherited knowledge, not invented knowledge. The Sumerians, nearest heirs of this region, stated in writing that their knowledge was inherited, from teachers, after a flood.

ITEM 3. The site was buried deliberately over centuries. There is no accepted explanation. The act preserved the site with an effectiveness that looks less like disposal and more like archiving.

ITEM 4. The 1963 survey filed the site as a medieval cemetery, and it sat ignored for thirty-one years. The find that rewrote human prehistory was missed by the professionals and reopened by one man rereading an old report. The file notes what else the professionals may have walked over.

ITEM 5. Pillar 43 carries the handbag motif: three handled objects along its top edge, the same object held by the Apkallu sages on Assyrian reliefs, by the winged figures of Olmec Mexico, and by carved beings from sites across the ancient world that officially never met. The same tool, in the hands of the teacher figures, on three continents. The consensus calls it a coincidence of basket design. The file calls it a signature.

ITEM 6. Karahan Tepe and at least a dozen Tas Tepeler sites extend the phenomenon across the region. Everything impossible about Gobekli Tepe happened simultaneously at multiple sites, which multiplies the labor, the coordination and the impossibility by an order of magnitude, and has been

absorbed by the field without comment.

ITEM 7. Klaus Schmidt, the one man with full command of the site and a public commitment to excavating it, died suddenly at 61, one year after publishing his synthesis. In the years since, permanent roofing and orchards have gone in over the unexcavated ninety percent, and the digging has slowed to conservation pace. The men who buried the site the first time used rubble. It works with olive trees too.

ITEM 8. More than ninety percent of the site is still underground, including geophysics returns showing enclosures larger than anything yet opened. The strongest evidence in this case has not been touched, and the current stewardship plan contains no schedule on which it ever will be.



Wild boar sculpture, museum replica of the site original, catalog MNR.25853. Carved from limestone with flint, no metal tools existing anywhere on the planet. The originals were found where the builders left them: arranged inside the enclosures, then buried with them. Nothing about the deposition was accidental.

Source: Museum replica of Gobekli Tepe original, inv. MNR.25853. Photograph released CC0 via Wikimedia Commons.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Gobekli Tepe is officially accepted and officially impossible at the same time. The textbook keeps the dates and discards the implication. Hunter-gatherers with no preserved practice runs raised ten-ton engineered monoliths, maintained a symbol system for a thousand years, and then spent generations of labor hiding it all underground.

This office assesses the site as the visible end of an older tradition, not the beginning of a new one. The competence came from before the Younger Dryas boundary, from a chapter the catastrophe erased, delivered by hands the Sumerians named, the Hebrews condemned, and the pillars depict without faces. The builders were remembering, and what they built, they eventually sealed, the way you seal a record addressed to someone not yet born.

Ninety percent of the evidence is still in the ground, under orchards and roofing installed by its custodians, and the excavation pace has slowed, not quickened, since the site became famous. Whoever buried this place the first time meant for it to be found. The file stays open until the rest of the hill is allowed to say what it came to say.

CASE REMAINS OPEN